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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

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Section Title(S): 3. Hxaro In The 1970s

Hxaro can be best understood as an extension of the broader kinship system. LEE (1984), in an extremely perceptive analysis of !Kung kinship, has identified three principles for designating kin. The first is what he calls Kinship 1, the standard kinship system that assigns kin terms to those related to ego, distinguishing nuclear family from collaterals and in most cases, collaterals from affinal kin.⁵ Standard !Kung kinship terms are structured by relative age and generation, and each term carries with it a relationship of joking or respect that delimits eligibility for marriage and a range of permitted behavior. The second is the name relationship (MARSHALL 1957) through which the sharing of personal names allows !Kung to extend terms of close kinship to distant relatives, if desirable. The name relationship thus destroys the logic of standard kinship, and continues to do so as demographic events add ever new names to the Kinship 2 universe. The discrepancy between Kinship 1 and 2 is resolved by the Kinship 3 principle called "*wi*" in which elders chose, amongst possibilities afforded by standard kinship and the name relationship, the terms that they wish to apply to juniors. It is elders who thus have the potential to manipulate kinship. After these three principles, *hxaro* comes into play. Kinship terms and corresponding relations of joking or respect determine to a limited extent only who has obligations to whom; through *hxaro* !Kung further activate the responsibilities of kinship and specify with whom they want to have more firm commitments. As with kinship, a !Kung's sphere of *hxaro* develops with age (WIESSNER 1982a).

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Hxaro carries its own risks because individuals may be unable or unwilling to be of assistance at any given time due to bouts of illness, absence from their own area, shortages of resources, etc. For this reason, !Kung distribute their partnerships widely, the average !Kung having 16.5 *hxaro* partnerships. To initiate *hxaro*, it is necessary have [107](#) some putative consanguineous relationship: of 995 *hxaro* partnerships studied, 71 % were indeed traceable

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on a person's genealogy as consanguineous kin, another 20 % were said to be consanguineous kin with whom the precise genealogical relationship had been forgotten and 9 % friends or affines.⁶ *Hxaro* is not done directly with affinal kin, but indirectly – one spouse takes gifts from his or her side of the family, gives them to his or her spouse who in turn passes them on to his or her kin. Exceptions do occur, the most common being when one spouse dies after many years of marriage and the other continues to do *hxaro* directly with affinal kin. New relationships may be initiated at any time, although they take several years to be considered established; conversely, if both partners lose interest, *hxaro* may be allowed to gradually die out. Essentially then !Kung use *hxaro* to activate kin relationships: kin who do *hxaro* feel responsible for one another, while those who do not leave kin relations casual or dormant. *Hxaro* thereby equalizes number of active kinship obligations despite variation in family size: !Kung from very large families can limit their sphere of obligations, while those from smaller ones can activate almost all of their kin ties.

5 Only spouses' siblings and siblings' spouses are given terms that do not distinguish them from collateral kin.

6 Although a consanguineous connection could not be identified on genealogies for all partners, the existence of one in the past seems to be an important criteria for establishing *hxaro*. Purely fictive kinship, such assigning a kinship term on the basis of the name relationship, does not provide a basis for *hxaro* partnerships though it certainly facilitates sharing when !Kung go to visit their partners (WIESSNER 1986).

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